



Digital Business | Smart SoHo

Get Self-published

Publishing needs are universal—here are publishing solutions that yield professional results, without the need for hiring professionals

Nash David

SoHos have publishing needs that have no end—brochures, fliers, bulletins, business cards—the list just goes on and on. Saving money is what SoHos swear by in order to stay competitive, and we're here to tell you just how to get it done.

Desktop publishing is the need of the day, and many SoHos are outsourcing their requirements. Why? Because even though their desktop publishing may not require the professional touch of an agency, the software that is used to achieve professional looking results will cost them an arm and two legs! Quark Express 7—about Rs 32,000! Adobe InDesign CS3—almost Rs 28,000! There's no way most SoHos can justify such expenses, especially for occasional publishing needs. That's where free and open source software comes in, and all you have to do is look around to find one that suits you. We found PagePlus SE (www.freerifsoft-ware.com) and Scribus (www.scribus.net) to be the best free desktop publishing software—you can find both in this month's CD.

Look Before You Leap

All creative work needs planning. Before you search for software, you need to identify your requirements. Whether it's a brochure you need to make, a flier, or a self-designed visiting card, before you do anything else, sit down with a pencil and paper and try and plan out what you want to achieve. This holds true for any sort of desktop publishing you may have—plan, arrange, execute!

Frame a mental picture of the most appropriate layout of text and images—this aids in faster execution of the task at hand. Go hunting for the best images to suit your requirement—use Google to find royalty-free images, or buy one from one of the many services that offer them. TIFF or PNG images with a resolution of 200 DPI or higher are generally preferred, because although images may seem alluring on your computer screen, results differ once they are printed.

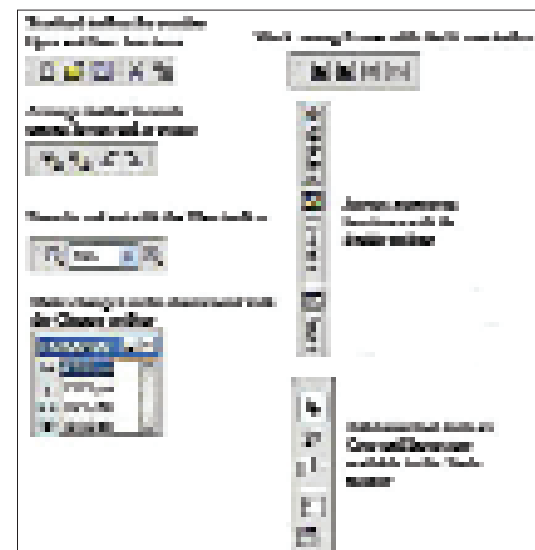
Take The Plunge

Of the two software solutions we mentioned earlier—Scribus and PagePlus SE—we prefer PagePlus: firstly, because it's extremely user friendly, and secondly, because it gives you more useful tools. Scribus, on the other hand, is too intimidating for a beginner in layout.

PagePlus is a flexible and effective solution. After you've installed the software, and before you begin designing, say, your business card, you need to make sure everything is organised. Gather all the relevant text and images—including your company logo—in a specific folder. Use this as your project folder. Now you can start by launching PagePlus.

The first task is to help you design your very own professional-looking business card. To do this, you need to follow some simple steps in PagePlus.

Digital Business | Smart SoHo



PagePlus' toolbars explained

The Right Layout

- Once you launch PagePlus, select the option to Create my own design. In the Choose a Design window, select Small Publications > Wide Business Card. Wide Business Cards are Landscape-oriented, while Tall Business Cards are Portrait-oriented.
- Before you start work on the card, in order to be certain that you view all the available tools, click on View > Toolbars and check all the toolbars.

The Business Card

- The blue rectangle that you can see in the middle of the page is to guide you while aligning the text and images. Similar to a grid in the background, it helps you decide the appropriate position of the various elements in the card.
- Start by inserting your company logo. To do this, go to Insert > Picture > From file (or you can simply press [Ctrl] + [G]).
- To insert text for your business card, click on the Artistic Text Tool (the alphabet "A") on the Tools toolbar. Alternatively, you can insert text from any file by clicking on Insert > Text File (or simply pressing [Ctrl] + [T]). You can further adjust the font size, height, width, line spacing and positioning through the Change toolbar.
- Each text or image component forms a box that you can easily move around the page, either by dragging with the mouse or using the cursor keys.
- After inserting all relevant image and text, our next step is to insert a separator, which is a line towards the bottom of that card, separating the address of the company. To insert a line, click on the Straight Line Tool. You will find this tool just below the artistic text tool. After selecting this tool, click on one end of the intended position and drag the mouse to the other end forming a straight line. You can adjust the position of the line by using the up and down cursor keys.
- In the same way, insert the address of your organisation and proceed to view your card by doing a Print Preview.

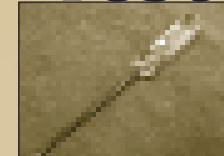
Write



Edit



Test



For almost 7 years, you have contributed to our success as a reader

It's time to take it to the next level...

We're looking for Writers,
Copy Editors and Test Centre
Reviewers, based in Navi Mumbai

Send your resume to
editor@thinkdigit.com

Remember to specify the post applied for in the subject line

